

Language Policy's Impact on Udmurt Lexical Development

The Udmurt lexicon has not developed organically but has evolved largely due to politicized efforts to control the lexicon of minority languages in the former Soviet sphere. The effective ideologies have not been consistent, however. Their goals and outcomes have varied widely since the 1920s and have even behaved as a pendulum swinging rapidly back and forth. This essay examines the different policies in question and their effect on the Udmurt language. These policies are also analyzed as products of their sociolinguistic environment and through the lens of theoretical frameworks. Finally, some informed recommendations are made to increase the status of Udmurt and its use in the community.

Background

Sociolinguistic Sketch

The Udmurt language is a member of the Permic branch of the Uralic family and is closely related to the Komi languages of the same region (Kaiser 2025: 126). In modern times, Udmurt speakers make up a substantial minority in Russia with roughly 255,877 self-identified speakers according to a 2020 census. Most speakers live in the Udmurt Republic, where Udmurt and Russian are both official languages. Regardless of its official status and large numbers, Udmurt is classified as “Definitely Endangered” by UNESCO as the speaker population steadily declines. Udmurt is taught in school, but only as a subject for a couple hours a week. This phenomenon reflects the use of Udmurt being very limited in everyday life. Russian has deeply influenced Udmurt language after centuries of contact and often supplants Udmurt use. Lexical developments detailed later in this essay highlight the extent of the Russian language’s influence on Udmurt.

Theoretical Frameworks

Language planning consists of two main elements: status planning and corpus planning (Kaiser 2025: 127; Krouglov 2022: 413). Status planning deals with increasing the prestige of a language to meet some ideological goal. Having status means that the language is used more frequently and in more important places. Increasing status is commonly done by selecting a specific language or variety for use in an official context like government administration (official languages of the state) or in the education system (language of instruction). Implementation of such a policy is done by legislation and through organizations both of the state and of the community. Other social factors, of course, may also affect the status of a language.

Corpus planning deals with the structure of the language itself (Kaiser 2025: 127; Krouglov 2022: 413). This type of planning is generally done by codifying the writing

system, the lexicon, or how the language should be used grammatically. Codification is not necessarily done just once. As languages evolve, elaboration is needed to respond to new natural developments. Language management is the process of monitoring for these changes, evaluating them, and establishing the new standard.

While language planning and management is traditionally accomplished by a national or regional government, they are not the only parties with influence on a language's development. There are three levels of influence: macro level, meso level, and micro level (Krouglov 2022: 414). These three levels have also been described as action from above (macro), from the side (meso), and from below (micro) (Benson & Kosonen 2021: 34–35). Macro-level influence or influence from above comes from countries or autonomous regions with power. As previously discussed, this entails measures like official language designations, national educational policy, and other legislation. Meso-level influence or influence from the side comes from secondary institutions with relevant expertise. These include United Nations (UN) agencies, non-governmental organizations (NGOs), donors, and academics. Some of the language planning measures available to them are pilot programs, material creation, orthographical development, and advocacy. Finally, micro-level influence or influence from below comes from local groups and individuals with vested interest. These include religious groups, cultural associations, and in the sphere of education, parent-teacher organizations (PTOs). Some of the language planning measures available to them are grassroots literacy campaigns and other local initiatives. Action at any one of these levels has the potential to influence action on another level (Benson & Kosonen 2021: 36).

It is worth mentioning that just because language planning may prescribe a certain practice or ideology, that does not mean that said practice or ideology is actualized. According to Spolsky's model, language policy consists of language practices, language ideologies, and language management (Spolsky 2005: 2154). While all components may influence each other, they are rarely congruent (2160). A common example of this incongruence is the idea of a monolingual nation state. For example, although France has attempted to establish French primacy for hundreds of years through various means of language management, it has still not succeeded in eradicating its regional languages (2156). The linguistic reality is always markedly more complicated and multilingual than what the constitution may claim. Spolsky argues that real language policy is not the written law but the actual practice (2161).

Periods of Development

1920s to 1930s: Indigenization

Following the October Revolution in 1917 and the establishment of the Soviet Union in December 1922, language planning in the Soviet sphere followed the ideal laid out by J. V. Stalin in 1918: “Each region shall select the language or languages that correspond to the ethnic composition of its population, and there will be complete equality of languages of both minorities and majorities in all social and political institutions” (Shelestyuk 2019: 3–4). This stance was an extreme macro-level promotion of the status of local indigenous languages such as Udmurt (4). At least according to the letter of the law, indigenous languages were the primary language in virtually all domains of use (i.e., administration, education, culture). Even the Russian speakers in non-Russian republics were encouraged to master the local language and be aware of cultural traditions. Ideologically, this policy of *korenizacia* (‘indigenization’) was intended to strengthen local identity and support for the new government in the Soviet Union (Edygarova 2025: 69). The policy was ultimately codified by the Congress into law after 1923 (Shelestyuk 2019: 4).

In practice, the policy was successful in engendering numerous efforts to standardize and purify the Udmurt language (Edygarova 2025: 69). For example, Udmurt intellectuals operating at the meso level engaged in a lot of corpus planning. One such intellectual, Trokai Borisov, founded the Udmurt-language newspaper *Gudyri* in 1918 and the literary journal *Kenesh* in 1926. Perhaps his biggest contribution to the Udmurt corpus was the creation of an Udmurt academic dictionary of fifteen thousand words in 1932. Another intellectual, Kuzebaj Gerd, taught Udmurt language and authored Udmurt readers for children. Gerd was active in creating native Udmurt terminology through compounding and other means to prevent the adoption of Russian loanwords. One such term, *knigavoz'on* (‘library’), was created by compounding *kniga* (‘book’) and *voz'on* (‘keeping’) (Edygarova 2022: 108). Gerd founded the Udmurt scientific association *Böljak* in 1922, another meso-level attempt to influence the development of a robust Udmurt lexicon (Edygarova 2025: 69–70). In 1925, the *RUDJA* (‘realization of the Udmurt language’) commission, a state institution (macro-level), was created with the express purpose of managing Udmurt terminology and coining new terms for administrative use (76). *RUDJA* also yielded a more well-defined orthography and grammar for Udmurt. The linguist Ivan Jakovlev wrote the first descriptive grammar of Udmurt in the Udmurt language in 1927 (77). All of these intellectuals’ efforts together contributed to the creation of a unified, standard, and healthy Udmurt language (76).

1930s to 1950s: Russification

By the dawn of the 1930s, the language planning pendulum had swung rapidly to the other side of the spectrum. While the state had once promoted diversity and purism, it quickly began to promote Russification and language mixing in their stead (Edygarova 2022: 107). These changes in language planning followed the centralization of power, the beginnings of totalitarianism, and an ideological shift at the macro level. The switch to Russian as the de facto national language was seen as necessary in order to industrialize the Soviet Union, to be more unified in the face of threats, and to build national cohesion (Shelestyuk 2019: 8). As a result, the status of minority languages was seen as a threat to this new national imperative.

This new unilateral, macro-level policy markedly degraded the status and use of Udmurt and the purity of its lexicon in several ways. Guidelines like those written in 1937 by Andrei Butolin encouraged the loaning of Russian terminology, a meso-level effort influenced by macro-level pressure (Edygarova 2022: 101). Butolin labeled the Udmurt purists of the last decade as “bourgeois nationalists” and encouraged Russian loaning as a way to build “a common language of Communism.” This kind of rhetoric is what led to the destruction of many Udmurt dictionaries and handbooks and the ultimate arrest of Udmurt activists Borisov and Gerd (100). Even newly-created Udmurt terms were abandoned for Russian loans. For example, Gerd’s neologism *knigavoz’on* (‘library’) mentioned above was abandoned in favor of the Russian word *biblioteka* (‘library’) (108). The speed of this pendulum swing is particularly remarkable. In a short decade, Udmurt had twice undergone significant change. As another example, by the decree of Moscow, latinized scripts for indigenous languages like Udmurt, just shortly after their creation, were quickly abandoned for cyrillized scripts alongside the introduction of Russian as a compulsory subject in schools in the late 1930s (Crisp 1990: 29). Language policy changes from this era significantly set back the development of Udmurt from the previous decade.

2010s: Revitalization

After the fall of the Soviet Union, macro-level language planning by the state has declined, but there have been some meso- and micro-level opportunities for Udmurt speakers to revitalize their language, particularly in the digital space. In 2013, there was an online competition to coin Udmurt terminology called Малпа выль кыл (‘Come up with a new word’) (Kaiser 2025: 124). The competition took place on the VKontakte social media platform and was a micro-level collaboration between three organisations: *MUSH* (‘bee,’ a working group), *Udmurtlyk* (‘Udmurtness,’ a cultural association), and *Shundy* (‘sun,’ a youth group) (129).

Participants were given a list of pre-selected Russian words for which to generate Udmurt replacements (128). The best neologisms were selected by a combination of public vote and a panel of experts. One example of a winning word to replace the Russian *skidka* ('discount') is *dunkuleston* ('discount'), which is a compound of *dun* ('price') and *kuleston* ('reduction') (131). Unfortunately, according to a corpus study, only a small number of terms that were created made their way into standard use (138). Without simultaneously increasing the prestige of Udmurt language in the community, it is unlikely that native terms could ever gain traction. The community is highly bilingual and still experiences some negative perceptions of Udmurt (136). Corpus planning and status planning need to occur simultaneously. While the pendulum has swung somewhat back toward the sentiments of the 1920s, the strength of the movement now is nowhere near as strong as it was back then.

Conclusion

Summary

Since the 1920s, Soviet and Russian language policy has had a huge impact on the development of Udmurt's lexicon. The Soviet state was initially supportive of indigenous language development and use in an effort to earn the trust of each republic. Macro-level practices such as granting official language status, promoting language use in schools, and creating administrative terminology were put into place. These ideals also inspired meso-level practices by academics like the establishment of newspapers and journals and the documentation of Udmurt in the form of grammars and dictionaries. State support quickly soured and turned to an attitude of suppression and control already in the 1930s. Udmurt purists were jailed and their work was destroyed. The use of Russian terminology and the Cyrillic alphabet was encouraged to promote conformity throughout the Soviet Union. More recently, micro-level efforts strive to save the struggling Udmurt language. However, attempts to undo the Russification of the Udmurt lexicon have been unsuccessful.

Recommendations

While corpus planning efforts for Udmurt revitalization are still active, they will continue to fail without status planning efforts to raise the status of Udmurt. Speakers need to view Udmurt as at least equal in status with Russian for it to return to use in everyday life. Macro- or meso-level change may be required. One change that could be implemented would be increasing the use of Udmurt in schools. Udmurt could be used as a language of instruction, not just as a subject. There are numerous bilingual education models that could be adopted so that Russian and Udmurt maintain equal status. Another possible practice could be

instituting a language nest, a daycare environment where only Udmurt is used (Pasanen, et al. 2022: 69).

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